party spokesman tweeted. Soon, cases were being registered against Udhayanidhi, who's the son of Tamil Nadu chief minister M.K. Stalin, in far-flung Uttar Pradesh and Maharashtra. A sadhu in Ayodhya put a Rs 10 crore bounty on his head and Union ministers and BJP leaders like Amit Shah and Rajnath Singh condemned the remarks. Even the Prime Minister's Office weighed in, saying Stalin Jr's statement needed a befitting reply. Stepping up the heat, the BJP on September 5 likened the comments to Hitler's rants on the Jews. "Uday Stalin's meditated comment is unadulterated hate speech," the BJP's official handle tweeted on X, deploring the support offered by the Congress and the INDIA bloc for "Stalin's bile".

In response, the 45-year-old scion of the ruling DMK (Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam) accused critics of distorting facts, especially with the genocide barb. In a tweet, he called Sanatana dharma "a principle that divides people in the name of caste and religion" and said "uprooting" it is tantamount to "upholding humanity and human equality". And dug in his heels with the words: "I stand firmly by every word I said. I spoke on behalf of the oppressed and the marginalised." As the heat rose, Udhayanidhi started breathing more fire. On September 10, he described the BJP as "a poisonous snake that needs to be chased out of Tamil Nadu". Hitting out at his party's state rival AIADMK—the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam—he likened it to "a garbage heap that shelters the snake". "To eliminate the snake, we must get rid of the garbage. The people must be ready to remove the BJP and the AIADMK from Tamil Nadu in 2024."

Making bile-soaked comments against believers, especially Hindus, is not new for DMK leaders. It has been part and parcel of the Dravidian movement since the days of its guiding spirit, E.V. Ramasamy 'Periyar' (1879-1973), who spun his politics around vehement opposition to Brahminical dominance and gender and caste inequality in



"The Congress and I.N.D.I alliance must clarify whether the Constitution gives the right to make objectionable statements about any religion.... Why is hatred against Sanatana Dharma being sold in the name of *mohabbat ki dukan*?"

– Tweet by **J.P. Nadda,** National President, BJP



"While the prime minister remains silent on everyday issues impacting the common man, his cabinet focuses on #SanatanaDharma by spreading false narratives.... I urge our DMK leaders and cadre not to react to such diversion tactics..."

–M.K. Stalin, Chief Minister, Tamil Nadu, on X

SANATANA DHAR

- The expression 'dharmah sanatanah', which loosely translates to an 'eternal religious code', finds mention in the ancient Sanskrit text *Manusmriti*
- The word 'Hindu' has its roots in 'Sindhu', and was originally used by the Persians to denote the people linked to that geography. It gradually came to refer to the religion. The use of 'Hinduism' for the collection of diverse practices and beliefs distinct from other codified religions was formalised in the late 19th century
- The term 'Sanatana dharma' too gained some currency in the late 19th century as a substitute for 'Hinduism', partly because of its

Tamil Nadu. Udhayanidhi clearly sees himself in that lineage. "Whenever he talks about religion, this has been his line, though this is possibly the first time he has referenced Sanatana dharma," says political commentator N. Sathiya Moorthy. "Left to itself, Periyar's anti-Brahminism was dying a natural death, the idea having outlived its political, ideological and, at times, emotional utility. So, when GenNext Hindutva groups began talking about the concept of Sanatana dharma, there was bound to be a reaction. This is a relatively new foe for Dravidian ideology."

All the talk of Sanatana dharma, analysts point out, is interpreted as a revival of 'Brahmin hegemony' in Dravidian circles, keeping it distinct from 'Hinduism' as a faith and religious persuasion. The families of many DMK and AIADMK leaders, including Udhayanidhi's, pursue the Hindu faith in private while often professing to be atheists in public. His mother, Durga, is a staunch believer who maintains a huge puja room at home, and visits temples big and small, inside and outside Tamil Nadu, whether or not the DMK is in power. That said, many DMK leaders have come out of the Periyar-era